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# INDIA MUST LEAD CHANGE

The world is dodging climate responsibility and delay is not an option—India must act with urgency and originality

**THE GLOBAL CONVERSATION** on climate action has become unmoored from credibility. Declarations continue, but delivery falters. The architecture of international commitment is weakened. Most advanced economies continue to operate with carbon-intensive systems while offering timelines that exceed political cycles and ignore frontline realities. For India, the consequences of inaction are neither abstract nor distant. The risks are local, immediate, and intensifying.

India stands exposed to the full spectrum of climate volatility. The question is no longer whether India should lead, but whether it can afford not to. Conventional growth pathways are no longer tenable. Replicating the material intensity, spatial form, and ecological footprint of western development models would lock India into a cycle of vulnerability. The alternative is to reimagine it—grounded in sustainability, designed for resilience, and aligned with long-term national interest.

The task is formidable. Accelerating renewable energy deployment is essential, but doing so without addressing the fiscal condition of discoms and inadequacies of transmission infrastructure will deliver diminishing returns. Building climate-resilient agriculture cannot be reduced to technology adoption

alone. It requires comprehensive land and water governance, robust agrometeorological services, and financial mechanisms that reward conservation and productivity. Transitioning from coal involves a deeper reckoning—with state revenue models, labour dislocation, and regional economic structures that rely heavily on extraction. This is not a simple substitution problem. It is a political economy challenge that demands nuanced, long-horizon planning.

India's industrial strategy must also reconcile ambition with preparedness. While policy direction is moving towards green manufacturing and clean tech supply chains, several enablers remain underdeveloped. Domestic production of batteries, solar modules, and green hydrogen will not achieve scale or competitiveness without dependable infrastructure, stable offtake commitments, and regulatory certainty. The wider institutional ecosystem—from land and environmental clearances to logistics and capital access—requires strengthening if India is to become a credible global hub for sustainable manufacturing.

Financial architecture must adapt at an equal pace. A homogenised and made-for-India domestic carbon market has the potential to reprice externalities and

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